internationally accepted principle of the watershed or the highest crest line along the northern mountain chain became the basis of determining the boundary.

> 'The idea of a demarcated frontier is itself an essentially modern conception, and finds little or no place in the ancient world,' Lord Curzon observed at the beginning of the 20th century. Further, he pointed out that until then, 'it would be true to say that demarcation has never taken place in Asiatic countries except under European pressure …'[4]

The Sino–Indian border issue needs to be addressed at a faster pace, of that there is no doubt. For years both sides have been adopting fixed positions. The visit of the Indian prime minister, Rajiv Gandhi, to China in 1988 was a landmark event. It laid the foundation for a more vibrant relationship between the two Asian giants. It resulted in the signing of the agreement on maintaining peace and tranquillity along the border in 1993, during the visit of Prime Minister Narasimha Rao.

During Prime Minister A.B. Vajpayee's visit to China in 2003, both countries agreed to appoint a special representative to explore the framework of a boundary settlement. Any mutually acceptable solution will have to be an exercise carried out objectively based on the agreement on 'political parameters and guiding principles' signed in 2005. This approach will benefit both countries.

During my tenure as the chief we had an important visit by a Chinese army delegation led by General Liang Guanglie, the chief of general staff, during which we had meaningful discussions at the Army HQ and visits to field formations.

Subsequently, as the chairman, chiefs of staff committee, I led a tri-service delegation to China, during the last week of May 2007. I was privileged to have called on Vice President Zeng Quinghong and Foreign Minister Yang Jiechie in the Great Hall of the People, besides meeting the hierarchy of the People's Liberation Army, namely, General Liang Guanglie, the chief of general staff of People's Liberation Army (presently the defence minister) at the HQ of the Central Military Commission (CMC), and General Guo